

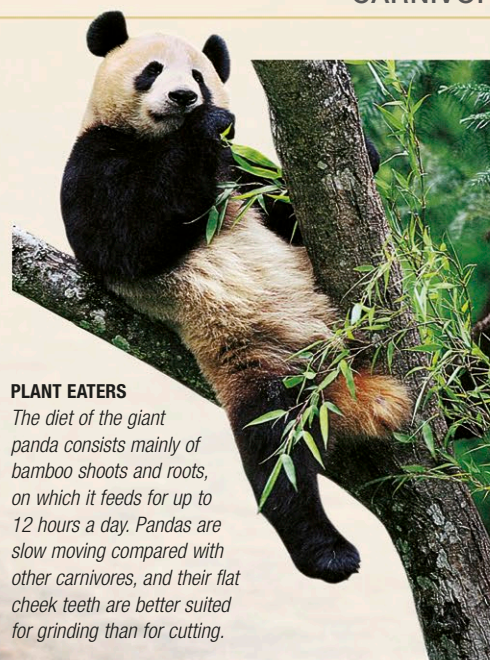
Feeding

Most carnivores live on a diet of freshly killed animal prey, ranging in size from insects, other invertebrates, and small vertebrates to animals as large as buffaloes and reindeer. Carnivores are generally adaptable feeders, seldom restricting themselves to a single food type. However, there are specialists—for example, there are pinniped species that eat only fish. Others, such as bears, badgers, and foxes, eat a mixed diet of meat and plants, while a few, notably the giant panda, are almost entirely herbivorous.



CARRION-FEEDERS

Hyenas feed on live prey and the remains of other animals' kills. Their particularly sharp teeth and strong jaws enable them to break bones and tendons that are too tough for other carnivores.



PLANT EATERS

The diet of the giant panda consists mainly of bamboo shoots and roots, on which it feeds for up to 12 hours a day. Pandas are slow moving compared with other carnivores, and their flat cheek teeth are better suited for grinding than for cutting.



Communication

Carnivores communicate with each other with scent markings, visual signals, and vocalizations. Scent messages, which have the advantage of being persistent, are used to define territory or to find potential sexual partners. They are left by spraying urine or leaving piles of feces, although some animals also rub scent onto objects from glands on their face, between their claws, or at the base of their tail. When animals meet face-to-face, posture, facial expression, and sound are used to pass on a wealth of information, including threats, submissions, advances to partners, and warnings of approaching danger.



GREETING POSTURES

Body language is an important form of communication for African wild dogs, which live in large packs. In this greeting ritual, adult dogs push their muzzles into each other's faces.



MARKING TERRITORY

Bears use trees to leave both scent marks and visual signs. Here, scent is being transferred in saliva and from glands in the bear's feet, while the sharp teeth and claws are being used to rip the bark.